



**VAULTS FOR PRESERVING
FAMILY STEM CELLS**

K.V. SUBRAMANIAM, President and CEO, Reliance Life Sciences

“By 2012, about 164 million Indians suffering from diabetes, cardiovascular and neurological disorders, and liver failure would benefit from stem cell therapy.”

SPINAL INJURIES

PIYUSH SHARMA, 30

While returning from Corbett National Park two years ago, Piyush Sharma had a car ram his motor-bike leaving him with an injured spinal cord. He was paralysed from waist down and doctors implanted a steel plate in his back. Stem cell treatment at a private hospital in Rudrapur, Uttarakhand, six months ago, made him capable of moving his lower limbs partially and regain bladder control. He says, “It has given me new hope.”

STATUS IN INDIA

Treatment of spinal injuries using stem cell therapy has been encouraging if not spectacular. In Chennai, a study of 280-odd patients found 23 per cent registering improvement.



there was internal bleeding. Normally, the only cure would be an expensive liver transplant. About nine months ago, doctors treated his liver with stem cells extracted from his bone marrow. Within a month, his liver showed signs of recovering and last week it was almost back to normal. Ahmed says, “I am back to eating mutton biryani without any discomfort.”

Apart from liver complications, Lifeline has treated over 280 patients having severe spinal injuries, including paralysis, with stem cells. Almost one out of four showed significant motor and sensory improvement. There have been controversies over whether Lifeline has been ethical in its methods of treatment and claims of success. But J. S. Rajkumar, its chairman, dismisses all such criticism saying, “It’s easy to rubbish our work but our data speaks for itself. People can always say why, but I say why not. It’s not a panacea but stem cells are a great alternative. It is already bringing down the costs of treatment.”

Controversies have always dogged stem cell treatment ever since it began